

600–1449

KNIGHTS IN ARMOUR

The arms and armour used by medieval warriors changed over time with new developments in weapons and improved technical skills in shaping metal. A knight needed to be proficient in handling many different kinds of weapon and had to be able to defend himself against similar weapons wielded by his opponents. In the early middle ages men fought with axes, spears, swords, and bows and arrows, either on foot or on horseback, and protected their bodies with short-sleeved shirts of mail made of interlocking metal rings. Plate armour began to be developed in the 13th century as a defence against more efficient crossbows, which fired bolts that could pierce soft mail. Armour was also sometimes made from leather hardened by boiling. By the mid-15th century knights were completely encased in suits of shining armour, draped with their heraldic coats of arms, draped with their heraldic coats of arms.

METALWORKING



10th-century helm

Single sheet of metal forged into a cone

Nose piece is sole face protection

Advances in the technology of metalworking played a large part in determining what knights wore. In the 10th and 11th centuries soldiers carried a shield as a first line of defence. They wore a coat of mail with a hood covered by a helmet that protected the head. Only a nasal guard covered the face. Sections of plate supplemented the mail over the centuries. By the 15th century soldiers and horsemen wore full plate armour, made from multiple sheets of metal, and no longer needed a shield.

While armour provided practical protection, chivalrous and romantic ideals inspired the knight in battle. His lady would give him a piece of her clothing – a sleeve, veil, or belt – to tie to his armour as a token of her favour.



Cylindrical great helm with decorations

Heraldic trappings

German knight In the 14th-century jousting field, a knight's appearance was as much a part of his display as the fighting. This nobleman bears his heraldic coat of arms. The "wings" on his helm were a Teutonic knightly fashion.



Pointed helmet with nose piece

Mail tunic

Quiver to hold arrows

Bascinet helmet with symbolic crown

Leg bindings

Mail "aventail" protects neck

Rerebrace: protection for upper arms

Vambrace: protection for lower arms

Padded jupon underneath surcoat

Sabatons (articulated foot plates)

Norman archer This 11th-century longbowman depicted on the Bayeux Tapestry wears mail: circular links of steel riveted together to form a flexible, armoured mesh tunic.

Edward III of England The 14th-century king wears a surcoat with the royal coat of arms over a padded gold jupon (seen at his elbows and knees). His low gold belt follows civilian style.